Beijing, it did not see India through the same lens. It did not expect that India could or would play too much of a spoiler in Sino-US relations. Nor did it need India to play a major role vis-à-vis China. This necessity had once made India important and useful. The lack of this need now resulted in relative indifference toward India.

Nevertheless, the White House did not think there was much benefit in continuing to bicker with the Indian government. There was some benefit, indeed, in trying to get bilateral relations back on track. With Moscow appearing to spread its tentacles around the world in this period, the US had an interest in limiting Soviet influence in the subcontinent—a goal that American policymakers believed was shared by their Chinese counterparts. Isolating Delhi would only leave the field to Moscow. US Ambassador to India Daniel Patrick Moynihan indeed believed that Kissinger "thought of India frequently"—unlike others in the Nixon administration—with an eye to how it could benefit Sino-US objectives.[6] Furthermore, even as India was not as important or influential in terms of US interests as it had been, it was just too big to ignore entirely. Thus, over the next few years, Washington worked to develop relations with India on a "more realistic" basis.[7]

The Indian government wanted to re-establish a working relationship with the US as well. By the end of 1972, Delhi found itself relatively isolated. India had a close relationship with the Soviet Union, but it had hostile, estranged, or indifferent relations with China, Pakistan, and the US. This was not the kind of diversified portfolio of partnerships that India preferred. This period highlighted the downside of India's diversification strategy. This strategy required options—others had to be willing to participate in India's diversification for Delhi to achieve the benefits of balance. After the Sino-US rapprochement, however, the US option dissipated, with the foreign ministry expecting India to become a "very low priority" in Nixon's second term.[8]

Declining American interest in India constrained Indian policymakers' choices. It meant too much dependence on Moscow. It also meant the need to continue to invest in preparations for a two-front war at a time when a number of internal issues needed the government's resources and attention. It further meant that the US was not available as a significant source of economic assistance, as well as investment and technology that the Indian economy needed.[9] Finally, despite Delhi's denials, it meant that others no